Rajiv often turned to Natwar Singh, not the cabinet minister for external affairs, for advice on key policies. For example, Rajiv's decision in 1987 to use the Indian Air Force to air drop emergency supplies to besieged Tamils in the Jaffna area of north-east Sri Lanka is attributed to advice proffered by Natwar Singh and not the cabinet minister or the professional bureaucracy. The Indian Air Force violated Sri Lankan sovereignty in conducting the ostensibly humanitarian mission. Later, Rajiv decided to send Indian peacekeeping troops to Sri Lanka without consulting his cabinet. In fact, even External Affairs Minister Narasimha Rao was informed of the decision after it had been made.[20]



For twenty-nine of India's seventy years of Independence, Indian prime ministers have also held the portfolio of external affairs. Even when external affairs ministers have been appointed, they have operated only under their prime minister's shadow. This runs contrary to the Westminster model of parliamentary system of government in which, according to Bandyopadhyaya, the foreign minister is 'the pivot' of the decision-making process in foreign policy.[21] The Indian practice of the prime minister playing a more direct role in making and executing foreign policy made India's foreign ministers less important than in most parliamentary democracies. A former foreign secretary lamented, 'I have even served foreign ministers who when I went for orders would say, "Why come here, just go down the corridor," pointing to the prime minister's office.'[22]

The pre-eminence of prime ministers in shaping India's foreign policy has endured over the years. As prime minister, Rao navigated his way in the post-cold-war world by boosting ties with the United States. He also initiated economic reforms to restart India's economy and championed the 'Look East' policy that was aimed at encouraging economic and trade ties with India's East Asian and South-East Asian neighbours. Rao was a